

CHHATTISGARH CREATES NEW MEANINGS OF FREEDOM

FREEDOM FROM MALNUTRITION, POVERTY, AND ILLITERACY

On completion of 75 glorious years of independence, India is celebrating the 'Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav'. However, there are several parts of the country where people are still waiting to attain freedom from the pangs of poverty, hunger, and malnutrition. Most districts still need better educational infrastructure. People in many parts of the country still lack basic education. Health facilities are in bad shape. In the midst of all this, Chhattisgarh, which came into existence as a separate state about 22 years ago, has been creating new meanings of independence for the last three and a half years. In Chhattisgarh, people have attained freedom from malnutrition, poverty, and illiteracy through constant innovative efforts. Here is a report:

FREEDOM FROM DEBT:

At a time when the entire nation is facing the brunt of inflation, agriculture has become a loss-making deal. In such a dire situation, freeing farmers from debt by a Government is nothing less than a gift. The Bhupesh Baghel - led Government in Chhattisgarh, soon after taking the oath, took the first decision to provide loan waivers to farmers. Farmers in the state were exempted from the repayment of agricultural loans of more than Rs 9,270 crore. At the same time, irrigation loans worth Rs 244.18 crore were also waived off.

TRIBALS RECEIVE THEIR RIGHTS:

In the tribal-dominated Chhattisgarh, the native tribes were deprived of their rights for years. The Bhupesh Government took the initiative to give the tribal people their fundamental rights of 'Jal, Jungle, Jameen' i.e., water, forest, and land'. The Forest Rights Act was implemented at the grassroots level to ensure the rights of tribal people in the aforementioned aspects. Individual Forest Rights Letters, Community Forest Rights, and Forest Resources Rights Letters have been provided to the tribal population of Chhattisgarh. The present Government has so far recognized more than five lakh forest rights papers and forest rights on about 59 lakh acres of land. The State Government also took the initiative to return the 4200 acres of land acquired by the Tata Industries Group to the tribal people.

FREEDOM FROM POVERTY FOR FOREST DWELLERS:

Forest produce is the basic source of livelihood for the people living in forest areas. The Government formed three and a half years ago in Chhattisgarh understood this and increased the number of forest produce purchased at the Government level by seven times. Till the year 2018, when only seven types of minor forest produce were procured in Chhattisgarh, it has now increased to 65 types of minor forest produce. The procurement figure has increased from 459.9 MT to 63,740 MT, i.e., 138 times during this period. The State Government has also increased the rate of purchase of minor forest produce. As a result, the number of minor forest produce collectors has also increased from 1.5 lakh to 6 lakh in this interval. On August 5, 2020, launching the Shaheed Mahendra Karma Tendupatta Sangrahak Samajik Suraksha Yojana, an insurance amount of 63 crore 43 lakh has been paid to 4,555 Tendupatta collectors during the interval up to 31 March 2022.

JUSTICE FOR THE PUBLIC:

In Chhattisgarh, "NYAY"(justice) is not a mere word. It has taken the form of a Governance plan and has reached the grass root levels of the state. The Chhattisgarh Government followed the path of "NYAY" or justice and expanded it with the slogan "NYAY: Sabbo Bar-Sabbo Dahar". The State Government is also providing financial assistance through Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay Yojana along with the support price for the purchase of paddy so that farmers can get fair value for their hard work. The State Government not only has procured paddy, but also connected the farmers with the Nyaya scheme by purchasing pulses, oilseeds, cereals, and horticulture crops at support prices. Due to this, farmers not only received the right price for their produce, but it has also elevated